

1849 Victor Emmanuel II becomes king of Sardinia–Piedmont and appoints Count Camillo di Cavour as prime minister. They institute liberal domestic reforms and increasingly act as the leaders of the Italian nationalist and unification movement.

1854–56 Count Cavour sends Piedmontese forces to fight with the UK and France against Russia in the Crimean War, as a way of enlisting their help for future Italian unification, as he realizes that Italy will not be united under its own efforts.

“I can offer you neither honors nor wages; I offer you **hunger, thirst**, forced marches, battles, and death. Anyone who loves his country, **follow me.**”

GIUSEPPE GARIBALDI, ROME, 1849

1859–70 The unification of Italy is achieved under the leadership of Victor Emmanuel II of Sardinia–Piedmont (proclaimed King of Italy in March 1861), Count Cavour, and the forces of Giuseppe Garibaldi. Most of northern Italy is united by Sardinia–Piedmont after the War of Unification against Austria in 1859, won at the Battle of Magenta with the help of French troops. In return, France gains Savoy and Nice from Piedmont. Garibaldi and his redshirts conquer Sicily and Naples in 1860 and then head north toward Rome before handing over their conquests to Victor Emmanuel II. Venice is ceded by Austria after a brief war in 1866, and Rome is occupied by Italian troops in 1870. As the country is unified, the national capital shifts from Turin to Florence in 1865 and then to Rome in 1870. Despite this unification under a single monarch, however, Italy remains more a union of provinces than a single country, with strong regional differences existing between the industrial and rich north and the agricultural and poor south.

1882 Italy joins Austria–Hungary and Germany in the Triple Alliance.

1889–96 As part of its efforts to acquire a colonial empire, Italy conquers Eritrea and Somalia in east Africa, but is defeated by Ethiopia (then known as Abyssinia) at the battle of Adowa in 1896, a rare defeat of a European by an African nation.

1911–12 Taking advantage of the Ottoman Empire's weakness, Italy seizes Libya and the Dodecanese islands in the Aegean in a brief war.

1915 Having abandoned the Triple Alliance, Italy joins World War I on the side of the Entente powers and attacks Austria–Hungary, fighting 11 battles along the river Isonzo east of Venice (1915–17) and then suffering a major defeat at Austrian and German hands at Caporetto in 1917. British and French troops are rushed to Italy to save it from collapse. In the closing months of the war, the Italians score a major victory over Austria–Hungary at Vittorio Veneto.

1919 Under the Treaty of Saint Germain-en-Laye, Italy is awarded South Tyrol and Trieste but is forced to give up claims on the Adriatic coast, which is given to the new state of Yugoslavia. It also gains land in Libya from British-held Egypt and from French West Africa. Italy, however, is dissatisfied with the peace settlement, believing it has received insufficient land or prestige as a result of having fought on the winning side of the war.

Proclamation at Teano

On October 26, 1860, Giuseppe Garibaldi (below, center) greeted Victor Emanuel II at Teano and hailed him king of Italy. Thus Garibaldi sacrificed republican hopes for the sake of unity under a monarchy.

DECISIVE MOMENT

FASCIST MARCH ON ROME, 1922

On October 28, 1922, groups of Blackshirts (fascist armed squads) began massing at locations outside Rome. Their leader, Mussolini (right), intended to seize power by marching on the capital, taking advantage of social discontent and the fear of a socialist revolution. Italy's prime minister, Luigi Facta, ordered a state of siege for the city, but the king, wishing to avoid civil war, refused to sign the order. As a result, the army did not oppose the fascists and Mussolini assumed power the following day. The event ended Italy's parliamentary democracy for 23 years.



1919 Italy and Yugoslavia dispute ownership of the Adriatic port of Fiume, which is occupied by the Italian nationalist D'Annunzio until he is ejected in 1921. The port is eventually incorporated into Italy in 1924. Italy also gains the Adriatic port of Zara in 1920.

1919–22 Nationalist and labor unrest provokes strikes in many Italian cities, notably Bologna, Florence, and Rome, as fascists, socialists, and communists battle for control.

1921 Benito Mussolini, a former socialist, merges numerous right-wing and anti-communist groups to form the Fascist Party, which takes a leading role in the industrial and civil disturbances occurring across Italy.

1922 Benito Mussolini asked to form a government by King Victor Emmanuel III, prompted by his threat to “March on Rome” to demand that a fascist government be formed in order to forestall civil war and a communist revolution. Mussolini becomes Il Duce, or leader, and heads a coalition of fascists and nationalists. He begins to crack down on parliamentary dissent.

1923 Corfu incident: after an Italian general and four assistants were shot while determining the Greek–Albanian border, Mussolini orders a naval bombardment and occupation of the Greek island of Corfu. After international pressure, Italy withdraws, although it receives a large indemnity from Greece.

1925 Italy continues to expand its African empire, gaining the Jubaland Strip from British-run Kenya, followed by more land from Egypt in 1926 and territory to the south of Libya from the UK and France in 1934–35.

1928–29 One-party rule is introduced.

1929 Lateran Treaties with the Vatican recognize the sovereignty of the Holy See.

1935–36 Italy invades and occupies Ethiopia.

1936 Rome–Berlin Axis formed with Nazi Germany. In 1937 Italy also joins the Anti-Comintern Pact with Germany and Japan.

1936–39 Italy gives massive military and financial support to General Franco's Nationalists fighting to overturn the Republican government of Spain during the Spanish Civil War.

1939 Italy invades and annexes the Adriatic state of Albania.

1940 Italy enters World War II on the German side and invades Greece and Egypt, although it is quickly thrown out of both. In 1941 it participates in the German invasion of the USSR, as well as acquiring control of parts of southeast France, western Yugoslavia and Croatia, the Adriatic coast, and much of Greece. It soon loses its empire in East Africa to Allied forces, and only holds out in Libya with German support until 1943, when it is evicted from North Africa.

1943 Italy invaded by Allies. The king deposes Mussolini and signs an armistice with the Allies. Mussolini is imprisoned but is helped to escape to the north, where he sets up a republican, fascist government. Italy declares war on Germany, which promptly occupies most of Italy and continues to fight the Allies on Italian soil.

1944 Germans put up fierce resistance, especially at Monte Cassino. Allied landings at Anzio lead to the occupation of Rome.

1945 Mussolini and his mistress are captured and executed by Italian partisans.

1946 Referendum votes in favor of Italy becoming a republic.

1947 Italy signs peace treaty, ceding border areas to France and Yugoslavia, the Dodecanese to Greece, and giving up all its colonies in Africa.

1947 Marshall Aid helps rebuild Italy after the war and aids growth.

1948 Christian Democrats (DC) under De Gasperi head coalition.

1949 Founder member of NATO.

1950 Agreement with US on US bases to be located in Italy.

